



POLITICAL FAILURE: Leaders of the all-party delegation to the state; Shivraj Patil (right)

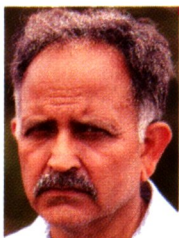
The Centre's efforts to broker peace have only ratcheted up tensions in both regions.

This is a state where the religious and ethnic sensibilities are only skin deep. But today passions and perceptions are calling the shots. Even a week after the army cleared the 450-km-long Pathankot-Jammu-Srinagar highway which is the Valley's lifeline for essential commodities, Kashmir is seething in anger triggered by an intense propaganda that the Jammu protesters have enforced an economic blockade of Kashmir. The separatists, for long divided and in a disarray, lost no time in grabbing the provocative issue to emerge out of the shadows, taking advantage of the political vacuum caused by the Governor's rule. They are now whipping up an anti-India frenzy to resurrect their lost cause. "It's a terrible and tremendous setback," said a top state government official. The flare-up has come at a time when the Valley was experiencing one of the longest spells of relative calm and stability with Pakistan-sponsored militancy at its lowest ebb. The state had been gearing up for the Assembly polls due in October.

Security officials reckon that the surcharged atmosphere on both sides of the Banihal tunnel has



virtually derailed the elections. The emotive issue has found an electoral resonance in national politics. For the BJP, it has been a god send, with enough pan-Indian potential to sway the political Hindu. The party lost no time in upping the ante, making the issue a key theme of its Lok Sabha poll campaign. It also vowed to support the Shri Amarnath Yatra Sangharsh Samiti, a loose conglomerate of Jammu-based organisations, backed by the RSS. As a part of its carefully-crafted strategy to keep the Hindutva motif alive, the BJP top brass showed up at the Aradhana Divas on August 11 in Delhi, depicting an ice shivlingam a la the idol of Shri Amarnath cave. "Denial of land to Shri Amarnath shrine is an affront to the Hindu sentiments and another example of flawed secularism," said senior BJP leader L.K. Advani, amidst chants of "har har Mahadev". The foot-soldiers of Hindutva have also pitched in, beginning with the VHP-organised 'chakka jam'. With Shri Amarnath land row arousing strong passions in Jammu and



"It's a people's movement to force the Government to assuage the hurt Hindu sentiments."

OM PARKASH, JAMMU BUSINESSMAN